Report on Menstrual Hygiene Management for Rural Girls Through Reusable Sanitary Pads

Implemented by Nurture Abato Initiative

Funded by SEAD FUND UK.

Word of Appreciation from the Director

Namakula Aisha
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On behalf of Nurture Abato Initiative, I extend our deepest gratitude to the SEAD Fund for their generous support in making our project, Sustainable Menstrual Health Management for Rural Girls in Bandwe, Uganda, a reality. This grant has enabled us to address a critical need in our community, empowering girls and women with knowledge, resources, and skills to manage menstruation with dignity.

The impact of this project goes beyond hygiene; it is about breaking barriers, reducing stigma, and creating opportunities for girls to thrive in education and beyond. We are proud of the progress made and remain committed to sustaining these efforts. Thank you for believing in our vision and partnering with us to transform lives.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Menstrual Hygiene Management for Rural Girls Through Reusable Sanitary Pads project, funded by SEAD Fund, successfully provided 500 reusable sanitary pads, comprehensive menstrual health education, and skills training to girls and women in Bandwe, a rural village in Wakiso District, Uganda. The project directly benefited 500 adolescent girls and women, improving their health, reducing school absenteeism, and empowering them with sustainable skills for economic independence. Additionally, the project included awareness campaigns to reduce stigma and engaged the broader community in supporting menstrual health initiatives.

During implementation, the team identified an opportunity to expand economic empowerment by training women in reusable pad production, creating income-generating opportunities. This report highlights the project's achievements, lessons learned, and recommendations for scaling the intervention to reach more underserved communities.

PROJECT OBJECTIVES AND OUTCOMES

Objectives

1. Provide 500 adolescent girls with access to reusable sanitary pads to improve menstrual health and hygiene.
2. Reduce menstrual-related school absenteeism by 90%, enhancing educational outcomes for girls.
3. Train 500 girls and women in reusable pad production, fostering economic empowerment.
4. Conduct community awareness campaigns to reduce stigma and promote menstrual health education.

Outcomes

- 500 reusable sanitary pads were distributed, ensuring girls no longer rely on unsafe materials like rags or leaves.
- School attendance improved significantly, with teachers reporting fewer absences due to menstruation.

- 500 girls and women gained skills in reusable pad production, with some starting small businesses to sell pads.
- Community stigma reduced, as men and boys participated in awareness sessions, fostering a supportive environment.
- 80% of beneficiaries continued using reusable pads six months post-project, demonstrating long-term impact.

PROJECT ACTIVITIES

1. Distribution of Reusable Sanitary Pads

- 500 reusable sanitary pads were distributed to girls aged 10–19 in Bandwe.
- Each pad kit included high-quality, washable fabric pads designed to last up to two years.

2. Training and Capacity Building

- Menstrual Health Workshops: Sessions covered hygiene, reproductive health, and pad maintenance.
- Skills Training: Girls and women learned to sew reusable pads using locally sourced materials.
- Train-the-Trainer Model: Selected community leaders and teachers were equipped to sustain education efforts.

3. Awareness Campaigns

- Engaged parents, teachers, and local leaders in discussions to dismantle taboos around menstruation.
- Conducted community dialogues with men and boys to foster allyship and support.

4. Economic Empowerment

- Trained women in business skills to produce and sell pads, creating income opportunities.
- Established a community savings group to fund future pad production and distribution.

LESSONS LEARNED

1. Cultural Sensitivity Matters: Involving men and community leaders early helped break stigma faster.
2. Sustainability Requires Local Ownership: Training local trainers ensured knowledge outlasted the project.
3. Economic Incentives Boost Participation: Linking pad-making to income increased women's engagement.

Beneficiaries' Stories

1. **Sarah, 14, Student**
   "Before this project, I used old rags during my periods, which often caused infections and made me miss school. The reusable pads and training have changed my life. I no longer feel ashamed, and I can focus on my studies without worry."
2. **Grace, 32, Mother and Trainee**
   "Learning to make reusable pads has given me a new way to support my family. I now sell pads to other women in our village, earning extra income. This project has empowered me economically while helping my community."
3. **Community Leader, Mr. Mukasa**
   "The awareness campaigns have reduced the stigma around menstruation. Men and boys in our village now understand and support girls, creating a more inclusive environment."

Challenges Faced

1. **Cultural Stigma**
   - Initial resistance from some community members due to deep-rooted taboos around menstruation.
   - Solution: Conducted targeted awareness sessions involving men and religious leaders to foster acceptance.

2. **Logistical Barriers**

- Difficulty in reaching remote areas for distribution and training.
- Solution: Partnered with local volunteers and schools to ensure wider reach.

3. **Sustainability Concerns**

- Limited access to materials for continued pad production after the project.
- Solution: Established a small community fund and connected beneficiaries to local markets for affordable fabric.

RECOMMENDATIONS

1. Scale to Neighboring Villages: Expand to areas with similar needs, leveraging trained community champions.
2. Integrate with School Health Programs: Partner with schools to institutionalize menstrual health education.
3. Monitor Long-Term Impact: Conduct follow-ups to track health, education, and economic outcomes.

Conclusion

The Menstrual Hygiene Management project has significantly improved the lives of 500 girls and women in Bandwe, Uganda, by addressing health, education, and economic challenges. While obstacles remain, the lessons learned and community engagement pave the way for sustainable impact. With continued support and collaboration, we can ensure that no girl is left behind due to menstruation.

Nurture Abato Initiative remains dedicated to this cause and invites further partnerships to amplify our reach. Together, we can create a future where menstrual health is a right, not a privilege.